
The Most Highly Anticipated Horror Movie of the Year Is Here. How Scary Is It?

Published by

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Estimated reading time

5 min

Added on

2026-06-05

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2026/06/backrooms-movie-2026-how-scary-is-it.html>

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*For die-hards, no horror movie can be too scary. But for you, a wimp, the wrong one can leave you miserable. Never fear, scaredies, because Slate's [Scaredy Scale](#) is here to help. We've put together a highly scientific and **mostly spoiler-free** system for rating new horror movies, comparing them with classics along a 10-point scale. And because not everyone is scared by the same things—some viewers can't stand jumpscare, while others are haunted by more psychological terrors or can't stomach arterial spurts—it breaks down each movie's scares across three criteria: suspense, spookiness, and gore.*

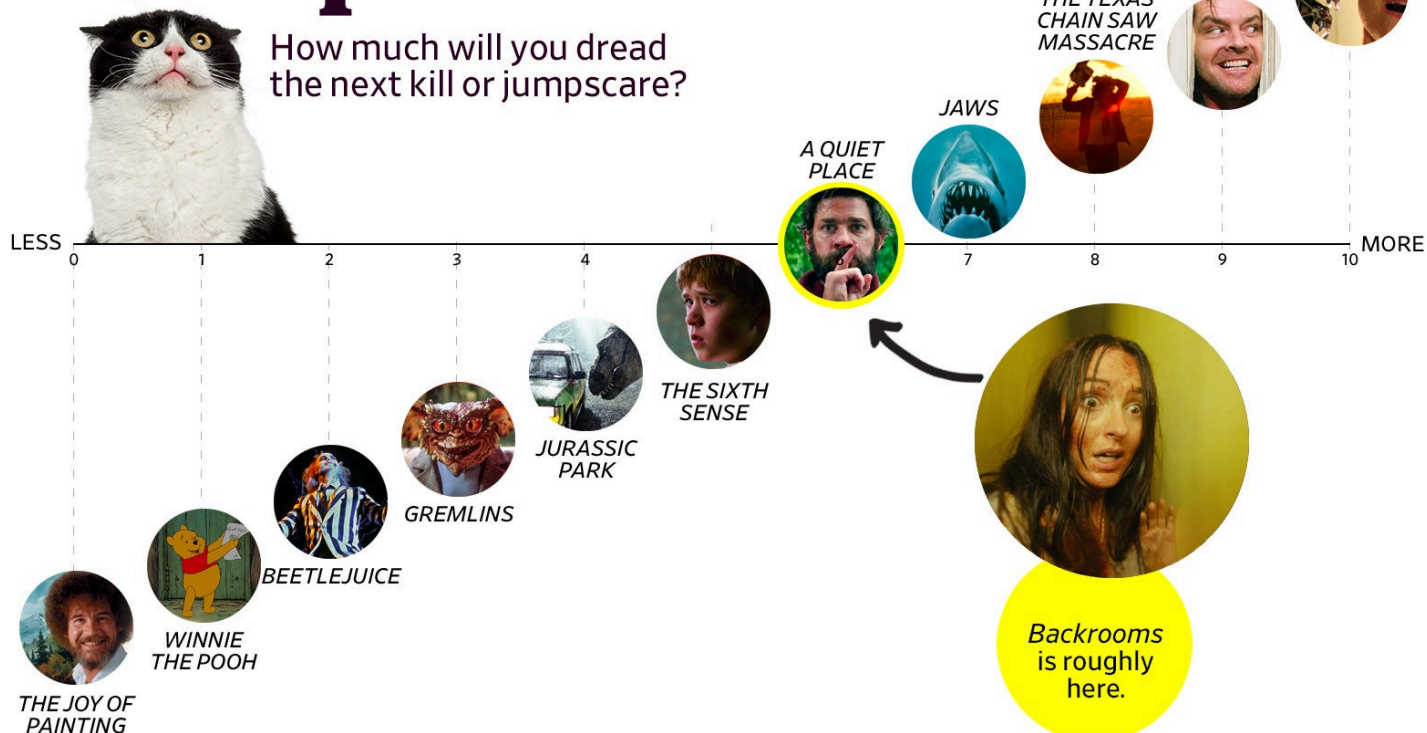
Backrooms, A24's trending horror film built on a [classic piece of internet phenomena](#), has officially become the buzzy studio's [highest-grossing movie, domestically, of all time](#). By Wednesday, within a mere six days of release, the film, which was one of the more highly anticipated offerings of the year, had netted both [critical acclaim](#) and \$100 million in the box office, officially surpassing the Timothée Chalamet-led [Marty Supreme](#), which earned \$96 million in the U.S. Shockingly, *Backrooms* came from the mind of a teenager: one Kane Parsons, now 20 years old, whose viral YouTube shorts he made about the creepy internet meme inspired A24 to tap the then-17-year-old to make a feature-length film.

Backrooms takes place in the 1990s and incorporates the found-footage genre into the story of Clark (Chiwetel Ejiofor), an alcoholic furniture store owner who is struggling with his recent separation from his wife. When he comes across an entrance to an unknown realm of endless office rooms—home to mysterious dangers lurking within—he chooses to explore these backrooms, unknowingly roping his therapist, Dr. Mary Kline (Renate Reinsve), into his precarious adventure. Both *Backrooms* and the other much-discussed film right now, [Obsession](#), are [evidence of the success](#) Hollywood has found in relying on YouTube-grown talent to craft today's most popular horror films. In fact, *Backrooms* has punched so far above its weight that Parsons is already looking to [make a sequel](#).

But none of that answers the biggest question surrounding the picture: Just how scary is it? If Parsons' early YouTube shorts are anything to go by, the answer would be very. But does the full-length *Backrooms* live up to the anxiety-inducing hype?

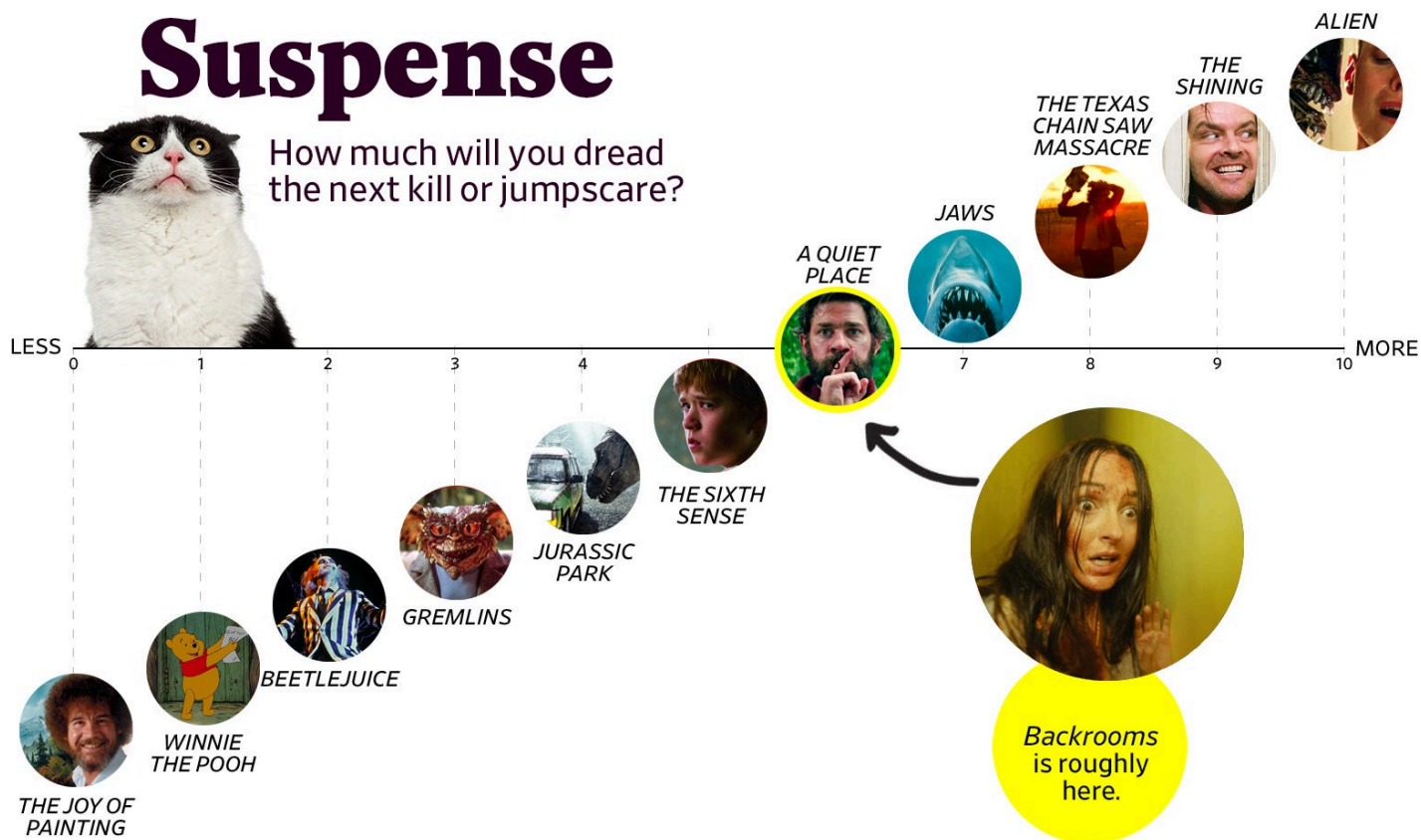
Suspense

How much will you dread the next kill or jumpscare?

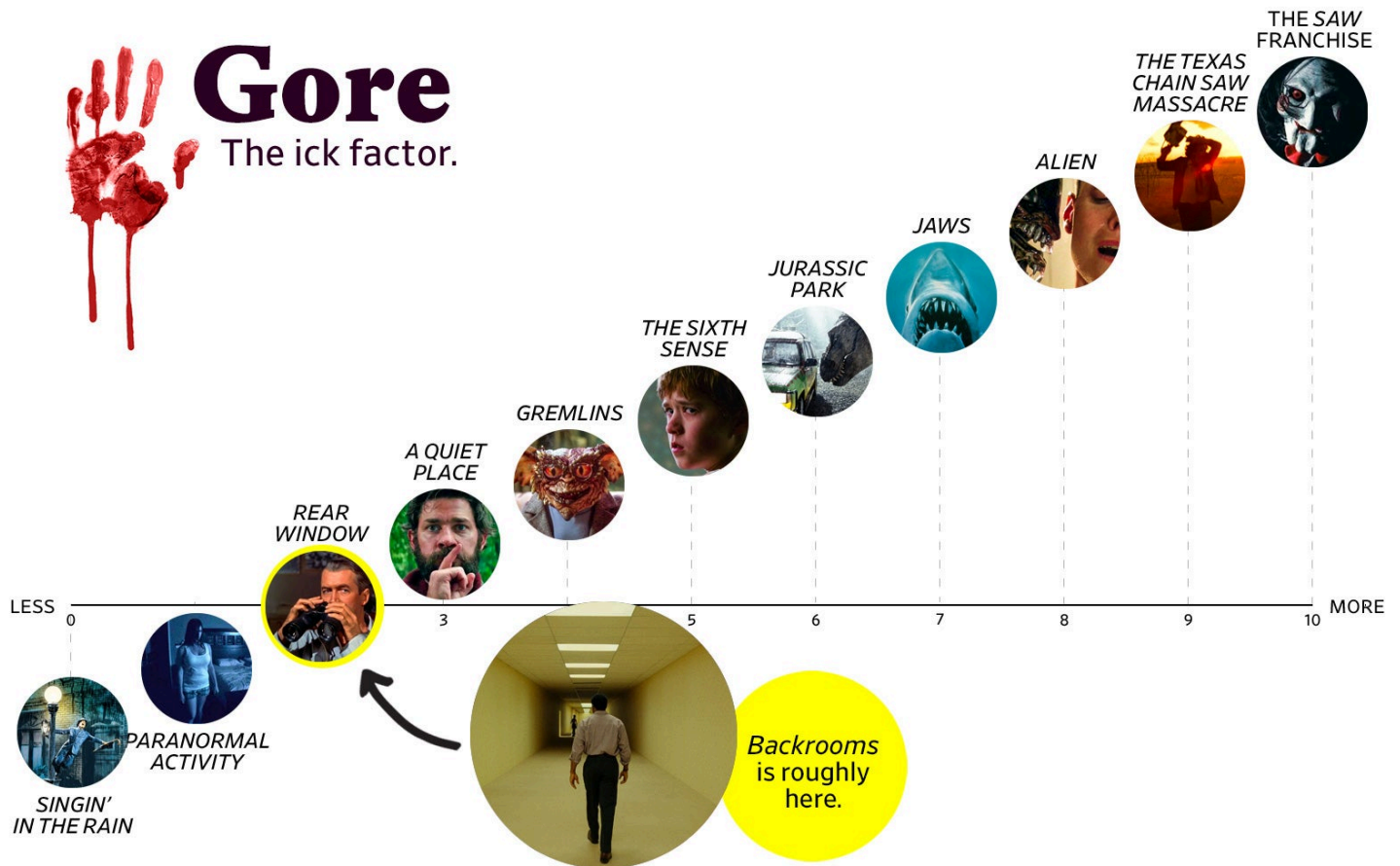


Suspense

How much will you dread the next kill or jumpscare?



It's inevitable that *Backrooms* approaches sound design much like [A Quiet Place](#), considering that most of the liminal space the characters are maneuvering through is eerily silent. Of course, this means that the hidden realm is a prime setting for a filmmaker to really maximize the suspense, as the characters creep around corners hoping nothing ominous is waiting for them on the other side. The setup begets plentiful jumpscare, but *Backrooms* keeps the audience on its toes by not always delivering jolts when you might expect them. However, rest assured, a good number definitely *do* come. The run time is full of odd appearances that get a rise out of the audience, like birds that squawk out of nowhere and themed rooms in the labyrinth that just get creepier and creepier—there's a particularly well-done scene involving a Christmas-themed room—until a release of tension resets you to ease, before the unease starts trickling back in again.



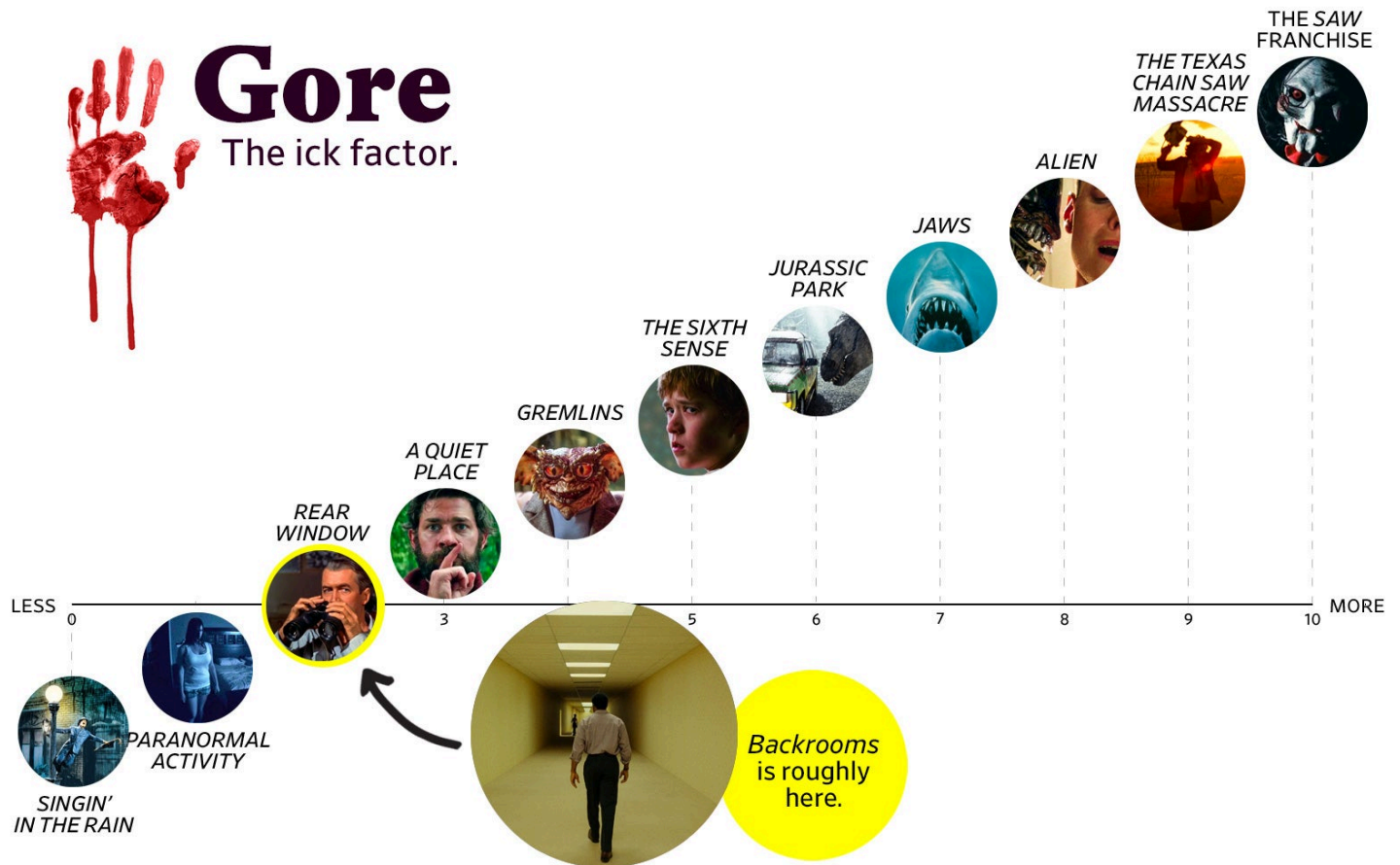


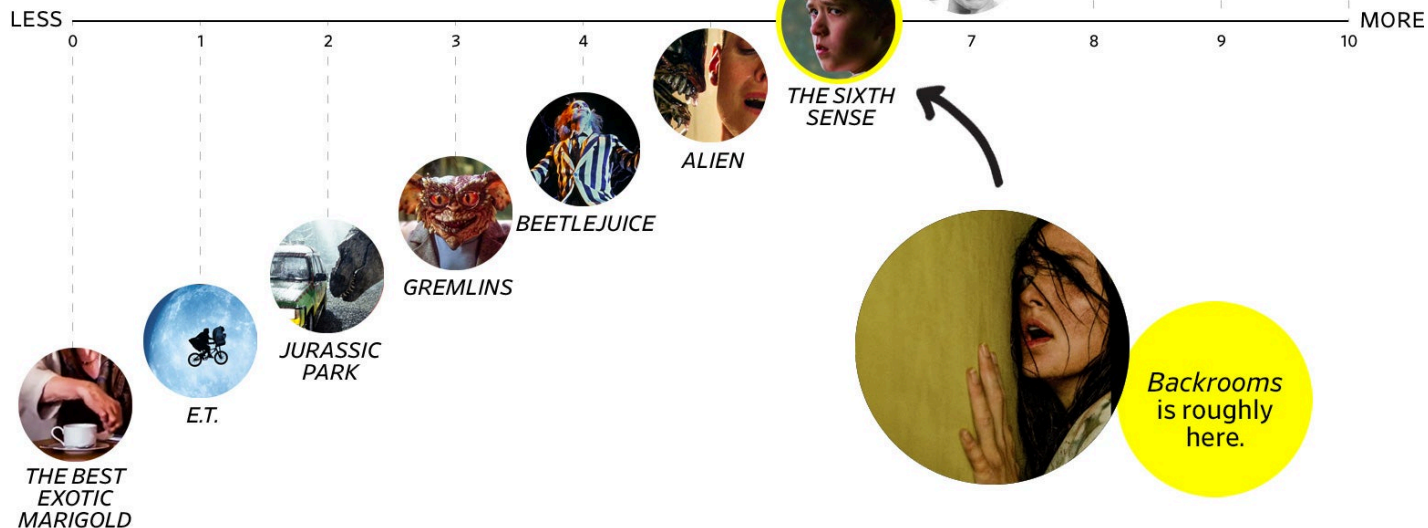
Photo illustration by Slate. Photos by A24 and Getty Images Plus.

As a film, *Backrooms* is not intent on scaring the living daylights out of its viewer or even grossing watchers out to the point of queasiness. Instead, it is more focused on raising goosebumps and making arm hairs stand at attention. Therefore, Parsons' world is not a particularly gory one. There are the occasional moments when the realm's monster attacks people, but the damage is done off-screen and leaves nothing but smears of blood on the set. Additionally, there are a number of humans who look disfigured in an unnatural, grotesque way, but it's not seriously upsetting as much as it is disquieting. At one point, when the lore behind some of the Backrooms' creatures is revealed, it seems like the moment will result in a moment of disgust. But, alas, that feeling is undercut by a fairly mundane concept.



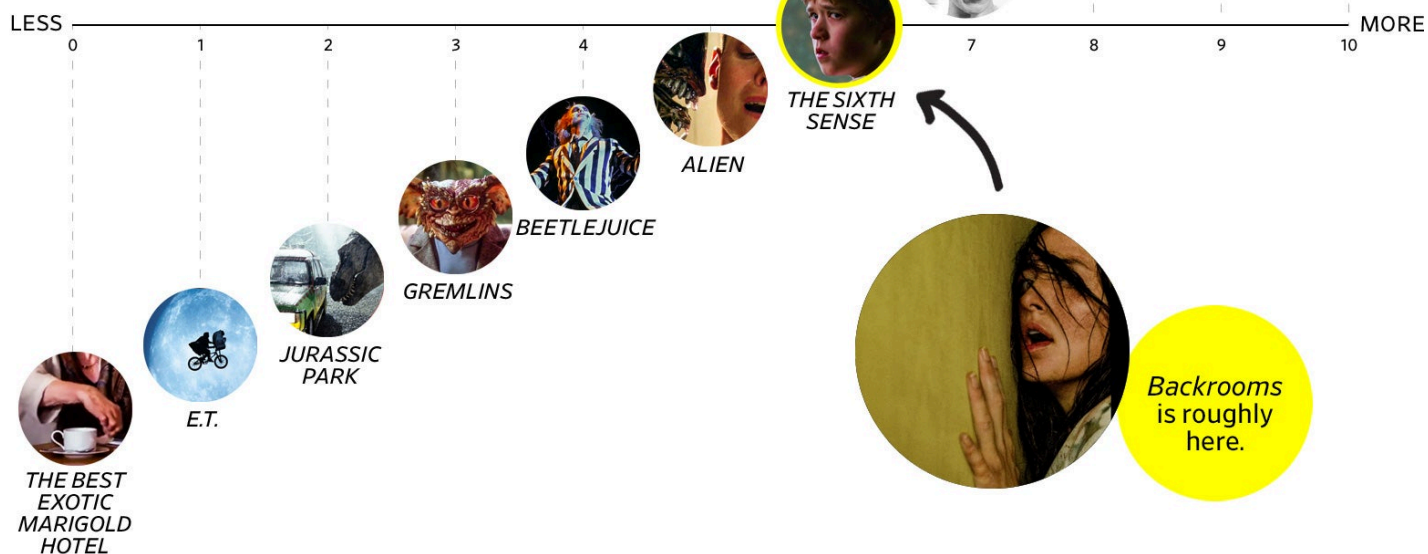
Spookiness

How much will it haunt you after the movie is over?



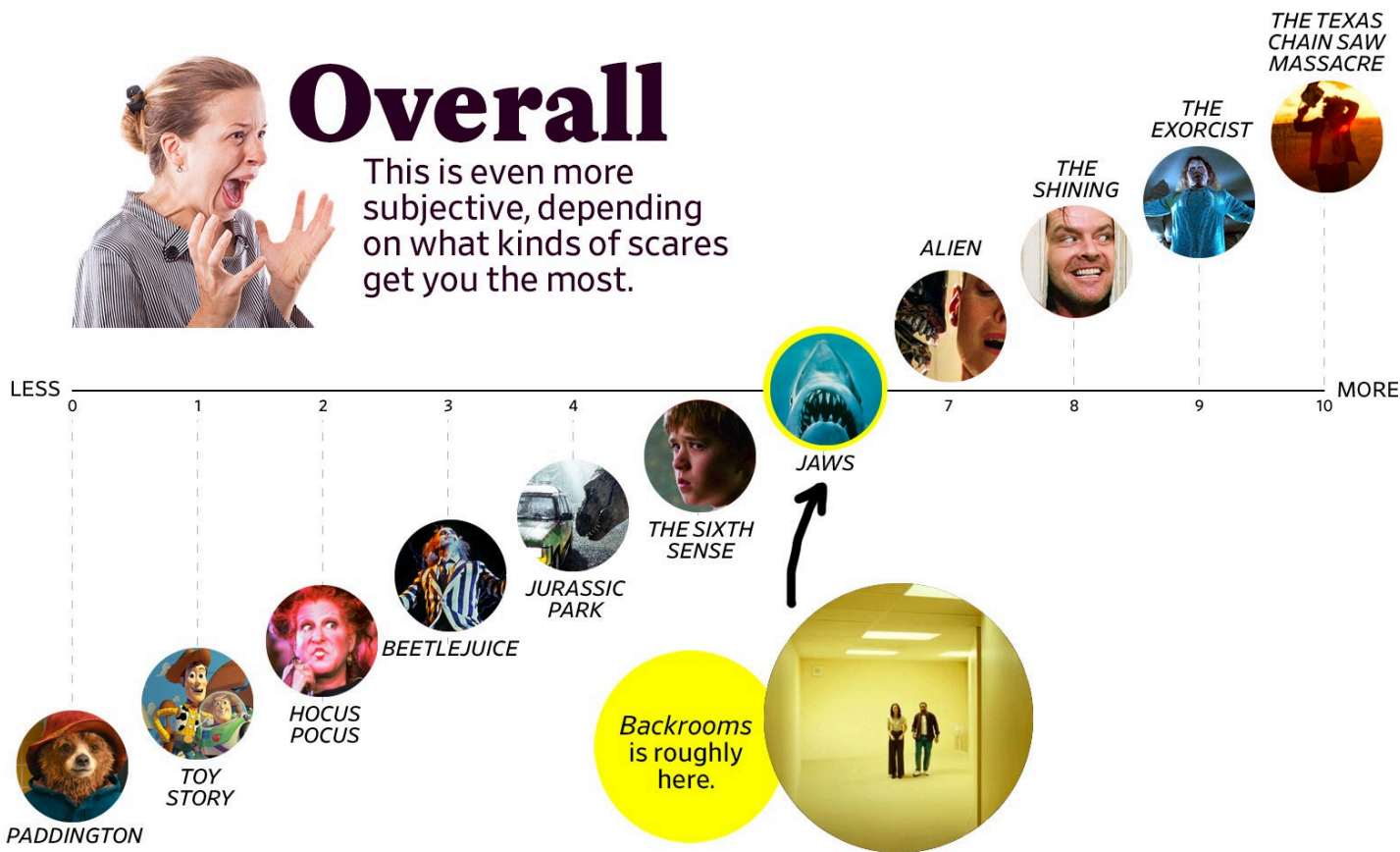
Spookiness

How much will it haunt you after the movie is over?



This was the hardest element of *Backrooms* to assess. The film succeeds at spookiness and disconcertion, really hitting its scary stride when the movie is in the thick of exploring the vastness of the Backrooms, trapping both the audience and its characters. Parsons is great at combining mazeophobia with the fear of the unknown.

However, the actual mechanics established in the film of how to access the Backrooms keep the plot from terrorizing you after the credits roll, when lingering nightmares might normally set in. In Parsons' world, you can enter the Backrooms by simply walking through a specific part of a wall in the furniture store basement. This is where some of the suspension of disbelief fails: The fact that a number of characters willingly reenter the creepy alternate reality, and are so uninclined to exit immediately even though they're able to, becomes a little distracting. When the worst of what's inside the Backrooms gets them, it's hard to feel much sympathy, and it's even harder to imagine their demise as something you'd ever fall victim to. Consider all of us who have even a modicum of common sense marked safe from knowingly entering a twisted Upside Down–esque maze of terror.



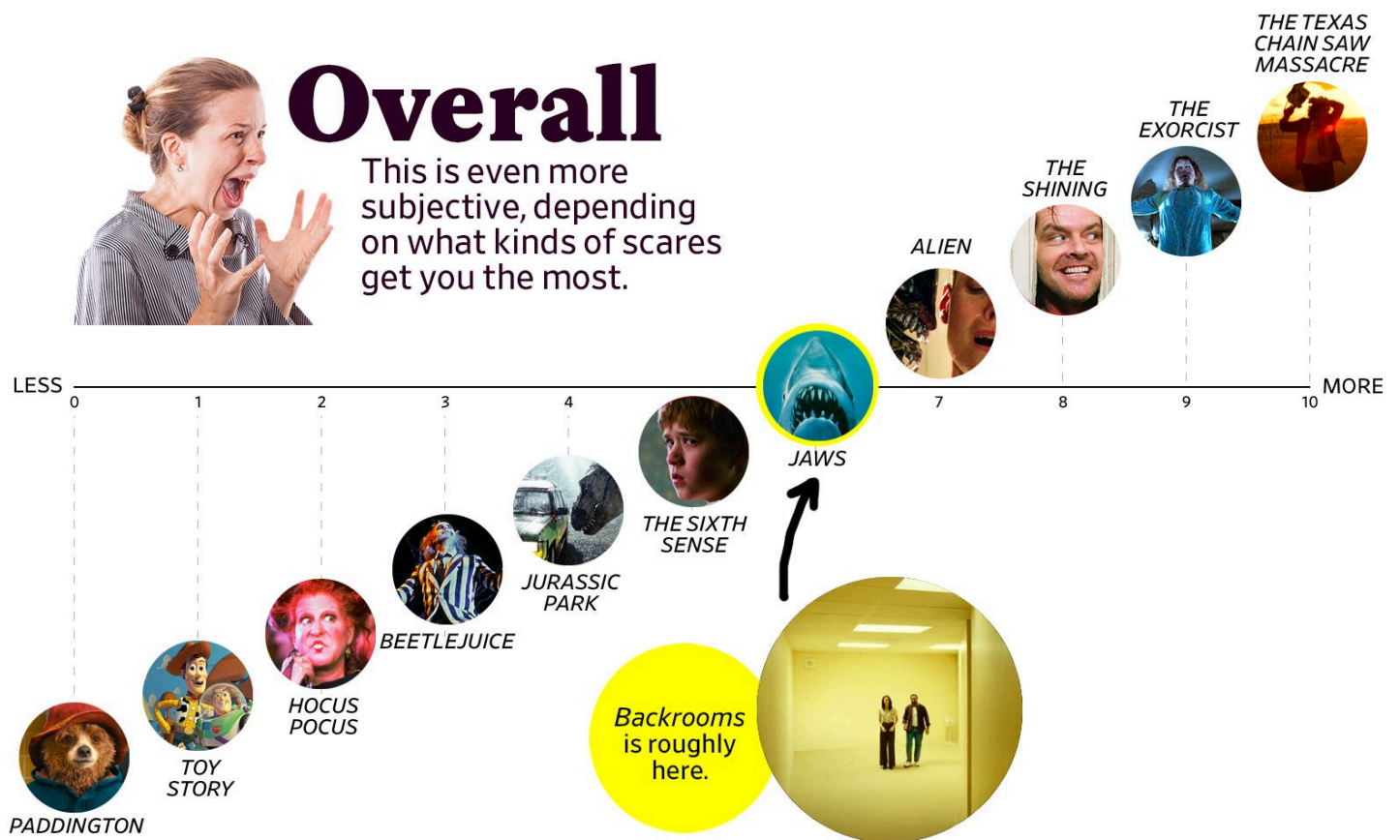


Photo illustration by Slate. Photos by A24 and Getty Images Plus.

The Backrooms part of *Backrooms* is great, well-rendered, and incredibly unsettling. Though the story supporting the film could use a little work, the production is overall an achievement. It is particularly good at doing the one thing all horror movies are supposed to do: eliciting feelings we'd rather not experience in our real lives. All of the mechanics and tactics that Parsons uses, his mastery of which are evidenced by the acute terror his earlier shorts evoke, are employed at the right moments and in ways that bring a fresh look to the horror genre.

With that being said, my mother always warned me to never walk through walls that defy the rules of metaphysics and lead to creepy-ass unending mazes of yellow rooms. All of the drama of *Backrooms* would be solved if they just turned around. And that, unsurprisingly, cheapens the overall effect just a tad.

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